CAREER

I Take Data Analyst Interviews. This Is What I Actually Check

The 6 things I score in every data analyst interview, what a weak and a strong answer look like for each, and how to prepare.

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- **What gets scored**
- **1. Approaching a vague question**
- **2. SQL you can explain**
- **3. Checking your own numbers**
- **4. Your own project**
- **5 and 6: Business sense and communication**
- **How to prepare for my interview**

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What gets scored

Tools are the entry ticket. These 6 decide the offer.

- **1. How you approach a vague question**
  Do you clarify before you start?
- **2. SQL you can explain**
  Not just correct, but reasoned.
- **3. Whether you check your numbers**
  Sanity checks before sharing.
- **4. Your own project, in depth**
  Did you really build it?
- **5. Business sense**
  Do you know why the number matters?
- **6. Communication**
  Can a manager follow you?

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1. Approaching a vague question

"Our sales are down. Look into it." This is how I start most case rounds.

- **Weak answer**

  Starts listing queries immediately.

- **Strong answer**

  "Down compared to what period? Is it all regions or some? Revenue or order count? Any recent changes like pricing or a site release?"

- **What I learn**

  Whether you can work without perfect instructions. That is most of the real job.

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2. SQL you can explain

I give a medium question, usually a ranking or month-on-month problem.

- **Weak answer**

  Silent typing, then a query that may or may not run.

- **Strong answer**

  "I will first get monthly revenue in a CTE, then use LAG to get the previous month, then calculate the percentage."

- **What I learn**

  Whether your logic is clear. A small syntax error is fine if your thinking is right.

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3. Checking your own numbers

I sometimes give data with a trap: duplicates, or a join that doubles rows.

- **Weak answer**

  Reads out the result as final.

- **Strong answer**

  "Total is ₹4.2 crore. That looks high for one month. Let me check row counts after the join."

- **What I learn**

  Whether I can trust your numbers when they go to leadership.

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4. Your own project

I pick one project from your resume and go 3 levels deep.

- **Level 1**

  "What was the question?" Most people answer this.

- **Level 2**

  "How did you handle missing values? Why that chart?" Half the candidates struggle here.

- **Level 3**

  "What would you do differently? What did the data not tell you?" This separates the strong ones.

- **How to prepare**

  Know every decision in your project and the reason behind it.

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5 and 6: Business sense and communication

The two that move you from "maybe" to "hire".

- **Weak business answer**

  "Revenue went down 12%."

- **Strong business answer**

  "Revenue went down 12%, mostly from repeat customers in two cities after a delivery fee change. I would check if reversing it for repeat buyers recovers orders."

- **Weak communication**

  Long technical detail before the point.

- **Strong communication**

  Answer first, then the reason, then detail only if asked.

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How to prepare for my interview

A one-week plan that covers all 6.

- **Days 1-2**

  Practise 5 vague case questions. Write 3 clarifying questions for each before solving.

- **Days 3-4**

  Solve 10 SQL problems while speaking your approach out loud.

- **Day 5**

  For every result you get in practice, write one sanity check.

- **Day 6**

  Go 3 levels deep on your best project. Write down every decision and why.

- **Day 7**

  Mock interview: answer first, reason second, detail last.

Bottom line: I hire the person I would trust to send numbers to my manager without me checking them.

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